



Zest

Service, sharp. — Complete User Manual

In-depth guide to the Zest hospitality operating system for restaurants, food halls, and truck pods — covering every station, every access level, and every major workflow.

Product · Zest Hospitality OS

Proprietors · Michael Blair & Andy Baida

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Audience · Owners, managers, floor staff, bar, kitchen, host, busser

Card payment processing in this demo is simulated. All other workflows described below are interactive in the product unless noted.

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1. Introduction & product overview

1.1 What Zest is

Zest is a hospitality operating system for bars, restaurants, multi-vendor food halls, and food truck pods. It combines front-of-house POS, kitchen display routing, labor timekeeping, multi-merchant settlement, inventory intelligence, guest ordering surfaces, and a SaaS-style HQ for operators who run multiple sites or vendors under one roof.

The product tagline is *Service, sharp*. The platform is built by **Michael Blair** and **Andy Baida**.

1.2 Core concepts

Concept	Meaning in Zest
Location / building	A physical site (restaurant, hall, or truck pod). Settlement and pads are location-scoped.
Vendor / merchant	A food or beverage operator inside a hall or pod. Menu items and KDS tickets carry a vendor id.
Check / order	A guest bill. In a hall, one check can hold lines from many vendors; the guest still pays once.
Ticket	A kitchen/bar fire group sent from a check, routed by station and vendor.
Access level (role)	Determines which screens appear after login (Owner, Manager, Server, etc.).
Host cut	Building operator share of vendor sales, configured in settlement settings.
Red-flag clock-out	Clock-out outside the minutes window after last closed ticket → supervisor review.
Pad	A truck parking/power slip in truck-pod mode.

1.3 How to use this manual

- Use the [table of contents](#) to jump by feature.
- Each major feature lists **who can use it** with color badges.
- Chapter 20 is a day-in-the-life guide per access level.
- Where the demo simulates money movement (cards, ACH), the manual says so explicitly.

2. Getting started

2.1 Sign-in & PIN pad

OWNER **MANAGER** **SERVER** **BARTENDER** **HOST** **KITCHEN** **BUSSER**

The login screen shows the Zest mark, PIN dots, and a numeric pad. Enter your 4-digit staff PIN. On success you land on the **home screen for your role** (for example, servers land on Floor; kitchen on Kitchen KDS).

- 1 Open Zest on the terminal, tablet, or browser preview.
- 2 Enter your PIN (demo PINs listed below) or use a Quick login chip.
- 3 Confirm your name and access level in the top-right header.
- 4 Use only the menu items shown — unauthorized tools are hidden.

2.2 Quick login by access level

Below the PIN pad, **Quick login by access level** shows one representative employee for each role. Each chip displays:

- Employee name
- Access level badge (Owner, Manager, Server, ...)
- Short description of what that level can do

Tip: Use these chips when training or demos so you can switch personas without memorizing every PIN.

2.3 Demo PINs

Name	PIN	Access level	Home screen
Morgan Blair	9999	Owner	HQ
Alex Rivera	0000	Manager	HQ
Jordan Lee	1111	Server	Floor
Sam Okonkwo	2222	Server	Floor
Casey Brooks	3333	Bartender	Bar
Riley Chen	4444	Host	Host / Waitlist

Name	PIN	Access level	Home screen
Morgan Diaz	5555	Kitchen	Kitchen
Taylor Kim	6666	Server	Floor
Jamie Cruz	7777	Busser	Floor

Manager override PIN for voids/comps in demos is typically the manager PIN 0000 .

2.4 Shell layout

- **Header** — brand, clock, location code, open check counts, signed-in name + access level, sign out.
- **Left nav (desktop)** — only items allowed for your role; section title shows e.g. “Server menu”.
- **Main canvas** — active module.
- **Bottom dock (phone)** — top shortcuts for your role + More when applicable.

2.5 Sign out

Tap the logout icon in the header. Returns to the PIN screen. Does not automatically clock you out of labor; use Labor time clock for that.

3. Access levels (roles)

Access is enforced in the navigation: if a role cannot use a feature, the menu entry is omitted. If something tries to open a blocked view, Zest returns the user to their role home screen.

3.1 Permission matrix (high level)

Area	Owner	Mgr	Server	Bar	Host	Kit	Bus
SaaS console	✓	—	—	—	—	—	—
HQ / settlement / integrations	✓	✓	—	—	—	—	—
Floor plan	✓	✓	✓	—	✓	—	✓
Order / pay	✓	✓	✓	✓	—	—	—
Kitchen KDS	✓	✓	—	—	—	✓	—
Bar KDS	✓	✓	—	✓	—	—	—
Host / waitlist	✓	✓	✓	—	✓	—	—
Labor & payroll rules	✓	✓	—	—	—	—	—
AI inventory / suppliers	✓	✓	—	—	—	✓	—
Drink AI	✓	✓	✓	✓	—	—	—
Menu / settings / cash	✓	✓	—	—	—	—	—

3.2 Owner

OWNER

Purpose: Full control of the site and platform demo surfaces including SaaS.

Home: HQ. **Typical tools:** SaaS, HQ, truck pod, settlement, integrations, labor, AI stock, all FOH/BOH modules, settings.

When to use: Configuration, multi-vendor payouts, supplier strategy, viewing every report, training all roles.

3.3 Manager

MANAGER

Purpose: Run the building day-to-day without platform SaaS billing controls.

Home: HQ. Includes settlement, labor rules, inventory AI, cash, menu, staff, promotions, purchasing, floor editor, etc. No SaaS console.

When to use: Open/close, comps/voids approval, period close, payroll readiness, 86 items, coaching floor.

3.4 Server

SERVER

Purpose: Table service and check ownership.

Home: Floor. Tools: Floor, Order, Takeout, Hall cart, Host (limited), Guests, Drink AI, Online orders board.

When to use: Seat (if permitted by workflow), build checks, fire kitchen, print/pay, multi-vendor hall ordering.

3.5 Bartender

BARTENDER

Purpose: Bar production and bar tabs.

Home: Bar KDS. Tools: Bar, Order, Takeout, Drink AI, Guests, Stock (awareness / 86).

When to use: Bump drink tickets, open tabs, recommend cocktails with Drink AI, 86 bottles.

3.6 Host

HOST

Purpose: Door and seating flow.

Home: Host stand. Tools: Waitlist/reservations, Floor (seat/turn), Guests, Online.

When to use: Quote waits, notify parties, seat tables, manage reservations.

3.7 Kitchen

KITCHEN

Purpose: Expo and line production.

Home: Kitchen KDS. Tools: Kitchen, Recipes, Checklists, Stock.

When to use: Start/bump tickets, follow recipes/plate cost, open-close checklists, watch low stock.

3.8 Busser

BUSSER

Purpose: Table turns only.

Home: Floor. Tools: Floor (mark dirty tables clean).

When to use: After paid tables show dirty, tap to clear for the next party.

4. Floor & tables

OWNER **MANAGER** **SERVER** **HOST** **BUSSER**

4.1 Floor map

The Floor view shows tables by section with status colors (available, seated, ordering, ordered, check printed, paid, dirty, reserved). Section filters narrow the map. Live counts summarize the room.

4.2 Seat a party

- 1 Tap an **available** table.
- 2 Enter guest count; confirm.
- 3 Zest opens a dine-in check assigned to the signed-in server and jumps to Order.

4.3 Open an existing check

Tap any occupied table to reopen its order in the Order screen.

4.4 Dirty → available (busser / host / server)

After payment, tables become **paid** then can be cleared to **dirty**. Tap a dirty table to mark it clean (available).

4.5 Merge tables

OWNER **MANAGER** **SERVER**

- 1 Enable merge mode on the floor toolbar.
- 2 Tap the primary table (keeps the check).
- 3 Tap the secondary table to merge in.
- 4 Lines and guest counts combine; child table is linked under the primary.

Use unmerge when the party splits or the combine was a mistake.

4.6 Transfer check between tables

- 1 Enable transfer mode.
- 2 Tap the table that owns the open check.
- 3 Tap an available destination table.

4.7 Bar tabs from floor

Open a named bar tab when the guest is not seated at a dining table. The check type becomes bar tab and appears in takeout/tab lists.

4.8 Floor plan editor

OWNER **MANAGER**

Drag tables, edit labels, seats, section, and shape (round / rect / bar). Add dining or bar seats. Remove tables that have no open check. Layout changes are saved in the demo store for this browser.

5. Ordering & checks

OWNER MANAGER SERVER BARTENDER

5.1 Order screen layout

- Left / main: category tabs and menu grid (filterable by vendor in hall mode).
- Check rail: lines with seat, modifiers, send state, voids/comps.
- Totals: subtotal, tax, auto-gratuity when party size qualifies, balance.

5.2 Add items

- 1 Select category (or All).
- 2 Optional: set active seat number for seat-based ordering.
- 3 Tap a menu item. If modifiers are required, complete the modifier dialog.
- 4 Item appears unsent on the check.

Happy hour: When enabled in settings and within the configured window, items with happy-hour prices ring at the discounted amount automatically.

5.3 Multi-vendor (food hall) lines

Each menu item can belong to a vendor (kitchen, bar, noodle stall, etc.). Lines show vendor short names. Sending routes tickets to the correct vendor KDS. Payment remains a single guest transaction (see Chapter 10).

5.4 Send / fire

- **Send** — fires unsent lines that are not held; creates kitchen/bar tickets grouped by station, vendor, and course.
- **Hold** — keep a course until you fire it.
- **Fire course** — release held items for a course.

5.5 Void, comp, notes, seats

Select a line to void (manager PIN when required), comp, adjust quantity (unsent), add notes, or reassign seat. Voids and comps write to the shift audit and sales adjustments.

5.6 Discounts & check notes

Apply percent or fixed discounts with a reason / promo code. Check-level notes print context for the team.

5.7 Print check & pay

- 1 Print check — marks table status “check” for the floor map.
- 2 Pay — opens payment dialog (card, cash, gift, etc.).
- 3 When balance hits zero, check closes; table moves toward paid/dirty.

Closing a check records the server’s **last closed ticket time**, which Labor uses for red-flag clock-out logic (Chapter 11).

6. Kitchen & bar displays (KDS)

6.1 Kitchen

OWNER **MANAGER** **KITCHEN**

Tickets list table/tab, server, items, modifiers, notes, course, and timer. Vendor labels appear when hall routing is active so expo can see which stall owns the plate.

- **Start** — mark in progress.
- **Bump** — complete / clear from active rail.
- **Recall** — bring a bumped ticket back.

6.2 Bar

OWNER **MANAGER** **BARTENDER**

Same KDS behaviors filtered to the bar station. Pair with Order and Drink AI for full bar workflow.

7. Host stand (waitlist & reservations)

OWNER

MANAGER

HOST

SERVER

7.1 Waitlist

- 1 Add guest name, party size, phone, quoted minutes.
- 2 **Notify** — marks notified (SMS is simulated in demo integrations).
- 3 **Seat** — assigns next free table and opens service flow.
- 4 **Cancel** — remove no-shows or walkaways.

7.2 Reservations

Book name, party, phone, and time. Statuses: booked/confirmed, seated, cancelled. Seat from the reservation row when the table is ready.

8. Takeout, online & hall cart

8.1 Takeout & tabs (in POS)

OWNER **MANAGER** **SERVER** **BARTENDER**

Create named takeout orders or bar tabs, then build items on the Order screen and fire to KDS.

8.2 Online orders board

OWNER **MANAGER** **SERVER** **HOST**

Lists web/QR/kiosk/marketplace-style orders with status transitions (placed → accepted → preparing → ready → completed). Guest-facing `/online` and `/kiosk` routes place demo orders into this queue.

8.3 Hall multi-stall cart

Guest or cashier builds a cart across vendors. One pay path; fulfillment still splits by vendor on KDS and settlement.

9. Payments, cash & tips

OWNER **MANAGER** **SERVER** **BARTENDER**

9.1 Payment methods (demo)

Method	Behavior
Card	Simulated authorization; optional last4; tips supported. <i>No live processor.</i>
Cash	Tender + change calculator; tips can be cash.
Gift card	Code lookup against demo balances.
Other / house	Demo paths for room charge / house account style tenders.

9.2 Tip suggestions

Payment dialog offers percentage-based tip chips on remaining balance.

9.3 Partial payments

Apply multiple tenders until balance is zero. Table status updates as money posts.

9.4 Cash drawer / shift

OWNER **MANAGER**

Cash view tracks opening float, cash/card/gift sales, comps, voids, tips, and expected vs counted close. Audit log lists sensitive actions.

10. Multi-vendor settlement

OWNER

MANAGER

10.1 The model (important)

A **location is a building**. Inside it, several food/beverage vendors fulfill items. Guests may order across vendors on one table visit. The server enters one check; items route to each vendor's production. The guest pays **once** (card or cash). Zest does *not* rely on Stripe Connect-style per-item routing to decide who is paid.

Instead, at period end the platform calculates each vendor's due amount.

10.2 Configuration

- Period type: daily, weekly, biweekly, monthly, or custom days.
- Card fee percent deducted from card-attributed product sales.
- Host cut on/off; percent of gross or fixed per vendor.
- Tax remitter: host vs vendor (policy flag for reporting).
- Current period start timestamp.

10.3 Live preview

Settlement view shows open-period totals per vendor: gross, card vs cash attribution, fees, host cut split, electronic payout, and cash due.

10.4 Close period

- 1 Review live preview and cash distribution report.
- 2 Close period — freezes a settlement snapshot.
- 3 Mark paid when e-payouts / cash envelopes are complete (demo status).

Demo note: ACH payout initiation is simulated. The ledger math and reports are real in-app logic.

10.5 Vendor portal

Vendors can inspect their sales, 86 their items, and view the last settlement row without seeing other merchants' full bank details.

11. Labor, clock & payroll rules

OWNER

MANAGER

Module: **Labor**. Staff time flags also appear under Staff for simple in/out, but Labor owns compliance rules.

11.1 Published shifts & clock-in window

Settings define how many minutes **before** and **after** scheduled start a punch is allowed. Outside the window, clock-in is blocked unless a manager forces override (demo messaging).

11.2 Red-flag clock-out

Settings define **clock-out red-flag minutes** measured from the employee's **last closed ticket/check**.

- Clock-out *within* the window → timecard **auto-approved**.
- Clock-out *outside* the window (or no tickets) → **pending review**, supervisor alert.

Use the Labor simulators (“ticket 5m ago” / “45m ago”) to train the two paths.

11.3 Supervisor queue

Approve as-is or correct punches (demo correction trims dangling time). Alerts resolve when handled.

11.4 Daily closeout

Configured time (e.g. 04:00). Running closeout forces any still-open clocks to pending review so the day can end cleanly.

11.5 Payroll

- **Auto-export** — only if every finished punch is approved / auto-approved / corrected.
- **Manual** — hold period for offline payroll processing.

Export payload is a demo JSON for processors like ADP (no live transmission).

11.6 Staff screen

Simple roster with tips/sales counters and quick clock toggle (does not replace Labor rules UI).

12. Inventory, recipes & AI stock

12.1 Classic stock screen

OWNER **MANAGER** **BARTENDER** **KITCHEN**

On-hand adjustments, receive quantities, par awareness for POS inventory items.

12.2 Recipes / plate cost

OWNER **MANAGER** **KITCHEN**

Link menu items to ingredient lines for costing and theoretical use.

12.3 AI inventory audits

OWNER **MANAGER**

Example: bar receives **4 bottles of vodka**. Through the week, cocktail recipes consume ml pours. The AI multiplies *sales × recipe* to estimate theoretical use, expected on-hand, variance vs count, and par status.

- 1 Open **AI stock**.
- 2 Run daily, weekly, or monthly audit.
- 3 Review variance notes (spillage, over-pour, receiving errors).
- 4 Adjust par / reorder points; receive stock when product arrives.

Works the same for food recipes (patties, buns, wings, etc.).

12.4 Suppliers

Connect demo suppliers (e.g. broadline foodservice, spirits distributors). Draft POs for items below par; submit to move status to submitted (simulated EDI).

13. Drink AI (bartender assist)

OWNER MANAGER SERVER BARTENDER

Guided questionnaire when a guest is unsure what to order:

- 1 Spirit preference (vodka, rum, gin, whiskey, tequila, surprise, none).
- 2 Profile (sweet & fruity, savory, sour/citrus, bitter, creamy, spicy, light).
- 3 Strength (session / standard / strong).
- 4 Review top suggestions with ingredients, build, glass, confidence, pairing notes.
- 5 Optional: add a mapped menu item to the open check.

Food pairing: If the active check already has food (burger, wings, ...), suggestions boost drinks that pair well with those dishes.

14. Menu, guests & staff admin

14.1 Menu admin

OWNER **MANAGER**

Browse categories and items; toggle availability (86). Hall items remain vendor-tagged.

14.2 Guests / CRM lite

OWNER **MANAGER** **SERVER** **BARTENDER** **HOST**

Guest profiles, loyalty points, visit counts, notes/allergies, gift card list.

14.3 Staff list

OWNER **MANAGER**

Roster, roles, PINs (demo), clock badges, tips and sales tallies.

15. Reports & cash drawer

OWNER **MANAGER**

15.1 Reports

Shift and sales snapshots: tender mix, top items, employee sales, open vs closed checks. Use together with settlement for vendor-level truth.

15.2 Cash

Open shift with float; close with counted cash; compare to expected; review audit trail.

16. HQ, integrations & vendor portal

16.1 HQ command center

OWNER **MANAGER**

Multi-location switcher, live sales tiles, open online order counts, hall settlement preview for the week, shortcuts into advanced modules (schedule, promos, catering, purchasing, delivery, campaigns, checklists, full package).

16.2 Integrations hub

Marketplace of payment, delivery, accounting, payroll, marketing, and hardware partners. Connect / disconnect, sync, view activity log. Connections are productized UI with simulated partner sessions — not live OAuth production keys.

16.3 Vendor portal

Merchant self-serve: sales slices, 86 board, last payout snapshot.

17. Truck pod operations

OWNER **MANAGER**

17.1 Pad map

Visual lot with pads (A1...C4). Statuses: vacant, occupied, reserved, maintenance. Assign trucks, clear pads, set maintenance.

17.2 Economics

- Monthly pad rent
- Power fee by amperage (30A / 50A / ...)
- Optional % of GMV

Generate period lease invoices; mark paid. Guest multi-truck ordering can still use hall-style single pay + settlement.

17.3 Lineup & power board

See who's on the lot today; monitor total amps vs service capacity.

18. SaaS console (platform)

OWNER

Platform identity (Zest; proprietors Michael Blair & Andy Baida), customer organization, plans (Starter / Growth / Enterprise), team memberships, location modes (restaurant, food hall, truck pod, ghost kitchen, catering), device enrollment, onboarding checklist, usage tiles.

Subscription charges are illustrative. Guest card processing remains simulated.

19. Settings, floor editor & advanced modules

OWNER **MANAGER**

19.1 Settings

- Restaurant name, address, phone, tax rate
- Auto-gratuity percent and party size threshold
- Happy hour windows
- Receipt footer, manager PIN
- Hall mode / online ordering flags
- Links into schedule, recipes, and other modules
- Reset demo data

19.2 Advanced modules (from HQ)

Module	Function
Schedule	Draft/publish labor shifts by employee and location.
Promos	Percent/fixed/BOGO style promotions by channel.
Catering	Event-style orders and deposits (demo).
Recipes	Plate cost and ingredient links.
Purchasing	Purchase orders receive flow.
Delivery	Dispatch board for drivers / couriers (demo).
Campaigns	CRM outreach drafts.
Checklists	Open/close task lists for FOH/BOH.
Full package / features	Enterprise feature matrix and pack center.
Payouts	Tenant payout list tied to hall economics.

20. Workflows by access level

20.1 Owner — open a multi-vendor day

- 1 Quick login as Owner (or PIN 9999).
- 2 HQ: confirm locations open; glance online queue.
- 3 Settlement: verify period settings and host cut.
- 4 Labor: confirm clock windows and red-flag minutes.
- 5 AI stock: run yesterday's audit if week-end.
- 6 Integrations: confirm payroll/SMS partners connected (demo).

20.2 Manager — service + close

- 1 Login Manager → HQ.
- 2 Cash: open shift float.
- 3 Coach floor; approve voids/comps with manager PIN.
- 4 Labor: resolve red flags before payroll.
- 5 Settlement: close period; distribute cash report; mark e-payouts paid.
- 6 Cash: close drawer; review audit.

20.3 Server — table from seat to pay

- 1 Login Server → Floor.
- 2 Seat table → add items from multiple vendors if hall → send.
- 3 Optional Drink AI for beverage upsell.
- 4 Print check → pay card/cash → thank guest.
- 5 When done for night, Manager uses Labor for clock-out rules.

20.4 Bartender — rail service

- 1 Login Bartender → Bar KDS.
- 2 Bump tickets; open tabs via Order/Takeout.
- 3 Use Drink AI for undecided guests.

- ④ 86 items on Menu/Stock when bottles die.

20.5 Host — door

- ① Login Host → Waitlist.
- ② Add walk-ins with quotes; notify; seat to floor.
- ③ Manage reservations as parties arrive.

20.6 Kitchen — line

- ① Login Kitchen → Kitchen KDS.
- ② Start and bump tickets; watch vendor labels in hall mode.
- ③ Consult recipes; tick checklists on open/close.

20.7 Busser — turns

- ① Login Busser → Floor.
- ② Find dirty tables; mark clean for host/server seating.

21. Troubleshooting & FAQ

I don't see HQ / SaaS / Settle

Your access level hides those tools. Sign out and login as Manager or Owner.

"Zest hit a snag" / React error

Use **Reset demo data & reload** on the error screen, or clear site data for the Zest URL. This drops corrupted local demo state.

Card payment failed / no deposit

Card rails are simulated. The UI records a successful demo tender but does not move real money.

Clock-in denied

You are outside the early/late window relative to the published shift. A manager must adjust rules or force clock-in policy.

Clock-out red flagged

You clocked out later than N minutes after your last closed check. Supervisor approves or corrects in Labor.

Vendor didn't get a ticket

Confirm the menu item has the correct vendor id and that you pressed Send. Check that vendor's KDS filter.

Settlement looks wrong

Attribution is by merchandise share, not tax. Host cut and card fees apply per configuration. Close period only after the service day is complete.

AI inventory variance

Check recipe pour sizes, unrecorded comps/spillage, and whether receiving was logged.

22. Glossary

Term	Definition
86	Mark an item unavailable.
Auto-grat	Automatic service charge for large parties.
Bump	Clear a KDS ticket as completed.
Check	Guest bill / order.
Comp	Zero-price a line with reason (manager controlled).
Host cut	Building operator share of vendor sales.
KDS	Kitchen Display System.
Pad	Truck pod parking and power slip.
Par	Target on-hand inventory level.
Red flag	Timecard requiring supervisor review.
Send / fire	Transmit items to production.
Settlement period	Window for vendor payout calculation.
Void	Remove a line from sales after it was entered.

Zest Hospitality OS — User Manual 1.0

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Proprietors: Michael Blair · Andy Baida · Tagline: Service, sharp.

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